



UPSCPREPNOTES

TOP 10 RANKERS STRATEGY

STRATEGY COMPILATION

UPSC CSE 2024

Top 10 Rankers

Complete strategies, marks analysis & key insights from AIR 1 to AIR 10

Authentic preparation strategies compiled from verified UPSC records, topper interviews, and coaching institute sources. Each profile includes paper-wise marks breakdown, detailed background, preparation approach by stage, and actionable insights.

Overview: Top 10 Rankers at a Glance

The UPSC CSE 2024 top 10 showcases remarkable diversity in backgrounds, optional subjects, and preparation approaches. The marks difference between AIR 1 (1043) and AIR 10 (1027) is just 16 marks across 2,025 total — less than one answer in a single GS paper.

Rank	Name	Total	Written	INT.	Att.	Optional
1	Shakti Dubey	1043	843	200	5	Political Science
2	Harshita Goyal	1038	851	187	3	Political Science
3	Dongre Archit Parag	1038	848	190	2	Philosophy
4	Shah Margi Chirag	1035	825	210	5	Sociology
5	Aakash Garg	1032	831	201	2	Sociology
6	Komal Punia	1032	856	176	3	Physics
7	Aayushi Bansal	1031	821	210	3	Sociology
8	Raj Krishna Jha	1031	831	200	5	Geography
9	Aditya Vikram Agarwal	1027	854	173	5	Anthropology
10	Mayank Tripathi	1027	843	184	3	Anthropology

Optional Distribution

PSIR: 2 (Ranks 1, 2) | Sociology: 3 (Ranks 4, 5, 7) | Anthropology: 2 (Ranks 9, 10) | Physics: 1 (Rank 6) | Philosophy: 1 (Rank 3) | Geography: 1 (Rank 8)

Background Distribution

Engineering background: 8/10 | Humanities/Commerce: 2/10 | Women in top 10: 5 (Ranks 1, 2, 4, 6, 7) | Number of candidates who improved from previous selection: 5 (Ranks 3, 6, 7, 8, 10)

Common Success Patterns

Resource Optimisation

Every top ranker limited to 1-3 standard books per subject. Deep revision beat shallow coverage.

Daily Answer Writing

All practised 2-5 answers daily + 1-2 essays weekly from early in their preparation. No exceptions.



Current Affairs Integration

Current affairs integrated into GS topics contextually, not studied as a separate subject.

Mock Test Discipline

They wrote 15-25 GS mock tests + 10-15 optional tests, analysed every mistake, maintained error logs.

Health & Consistency

Every ranker emphasised 7-8 hours sleep, regular exercise, and social connections. The UPSC journey is a marathon.

1. Shakti Dubey — AIR 1 (2024)

AIR 1

RANK

1043

TOTAL

843

WRITTEN

200

INTERVIEW

5

ATTEMPT(S)

Optional: Political Science & IR | **Hometown:** Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh | **Allocated Service:** IAS**Education:** B.Sc. Biochemistry (Allahabad University), M.Sc. Biochemistry (BHU)

Paper-wise Marks

Paper	Marks
Essay	100
GS1	112
GS2	125
GS3	86
GS4 (Ethics)	141
PSIR Paper 1	132
PSIR Paper 2	147

Background

Daughter of Devendra Dubey (UP Police Sub-Inspector) and Prema Devi (homemaker). Scored 10 CGPA in Class 10 and 94.2% in Class 12 from St. Mary's Convent, Prayagraj. Gold Medalist in both B.Sc. (86.5%) and M.Sc. (9.21 CGPA) in Biochemistry from BHU. Headed the Student Debating Committee at BHU. Her father's police service inspired her desire to contribute to society through civil services.

Preparation Strategy

Shakti's journey from a biochemistry lab to AIR 1 in her 5th attempt is a masterclass in perseverance. She started preparing in 2018 but failed Prelims in her first three attempts — 2019, 2020, and 2021. After three Prelims failures, she completely overhauled her approach: stopped blind fact-cramming, started using logical elimination techniques in MCQs, and studied 10 years of PYQs deeply. In 2023 (4th attempt), she cleared Mains but missed final selection by just 12 marks. She persisted and secured AIR 1 in 2024. Her preparation blended scientific rigor with policy acumen. She built answers on three pillars: Argument, Examples, Data — using neat headings, flowcharts, diagrams, data from Economic Survey, and Supreme Court judgments. For PSIR optional, she used IGNOU materials, Andrew Heywood (Politics/Political Theory), Rumki Basu (Public Administration), Rajiv Sikri and C. Raja Mohan for IR, with Shubhra

Ranjan's notes as supplementary. She kept International Relations current through Foreign Affairs magazines and ORF analyses. She maintained a weekly self-assessment journal rating her preparation across 11 parameters for rapid course correction.

Coaching & Mentorship

Enrolled in VisionIAS All India Test Series, Abhyaas Mock Tests, and Interview Guidance Program. Also NEXT IAS (GS, Current Affairs, Essay) and Vajiram & Ravi (GS Foundation, Test Series). Used PW OnlyIAS Interview Guidance Program for mock interviews.

Daily Routine

6:00-9:00 AM: Newspaper + current affairs note-making (The Hindu + Indian Express + monthly compilations). 10 AM-1 PM: Static subjects rotation (polity, economy, history, geography, S&T). 2-4 PM: PSIR optional (Paper I/II rotation). 5-8 PM: Answer writing + test series review. 8-9 PM: Revision.

Stage-wise Approach

Prelims Strategy

Overhauled approach after 3 Prelims failures: stopped blind cramming, adopted logical elimination techniques, studied 10 years of PYQs deeply. Focused on NCERTs for conceptual clarity, used VisionIAS/ForumIAS current affairs compilations. Multiple mock tests for exam temperament.

Mains Strategy

Built answers on three pillars — Argument, Examples, Data. Used neat headings, flowcharts, diagrams, Economic Survey data, and Supreme Court judgments. Practiced 4-5 answers daily. For Ethics (141), prepared structured case study frameworks and memorised ethical concepts with real governance examples from ARC reports.

Optional Strategy (Political Science & IR)

PSIR: Strong foundation in political theory (Western and Indian thinkers). Used Andrew Heywood, Rumki Basu, IGNOU notes, Rajiv Sikri and C. Raja Mohan for IR. Made concise 1-page thinker summaries covering core idea, criticisms, and contemporary relevance. Connected political theories with recent news (G20, Global South leadership).

Interview Preparation

Thorough DAF analysis highlighting her biochemistry background and Prayagraj roots. Multiple mock interviews with VisionIAS, Vajiram, and PW OnlyIAS. Stayed completely honest — never faked answers. Expressed balanced views with calm composure. Questions covered PSIR, dual degree pathways, women in science, G20 New Delhi Declaration.



Challenges Faced

Failed Prelims in first 3 attempts (2019-2021). Missed selection by 12 marks in 4th attempt (2023). Emotional toll of 5 attempts over 7 years. Contemplated quitting multiple times. Balancing science background with humanities syllabus. Called her journey a '7-year odyssey with emotional highs and lows.'

Key Insights

- Failed Prelims thrice — overhauled strategy each time, never gave up
- Missed selection by 12 marks in 2023 — used failure as fuel for final push
- Quality over quantity: limited resources to 2-3 per subject, revised deeply
- Strong Ethics (141) and Optional (132+147) were rank differentiators
- Weekly 11-parameter self-assessment journal enabled rapid course correction

2. Harshita Goyal — AIR 2 (2024)

AIR 2

RANK

1038

TOTAL

851

WRITTEN

187

INTERVIEW

3

ATTEMPT(S)

Optional: Political Science & IR | **Hometown:** Hisar, Haryana (raised in Vadodara, Gujarat) | **Allocated Service:** IAS

Education: B.Com (MS University Baroda), Chartered Accountant

Paper-wise Marks

Paper	Marks
Essay	144
GS1	102
GS2	121
GS3	90
GS4 (Ethics)	125
PSIR Paper 1	117
PSIR Paper 2	152

Background

Harshita grew up in Vadodara, Gujarat after her family moved from Hisar, Haryana. She completed schooling at Delhi Public School, Vadodara, then earned B.Com from Maharaja Sayajirao University of Baroda and qualified as a Chartered Accountant. She lost her mother to cancer early in life and was raised by her father and brother. Before UPSC, she worked with Believe Foundation on women's empowerment and health for thalassemic children and cancer patients. She achieved Best Paper award at the national CA students conference on 'Role of CAs in transforming India.' Her hobbies include acrylic painting.

Preparation Strategy

Harshita's CA training gave her strong analytical skills that directly benefited answer writing. She divided preparation into 90-minute focus blocks with specific objectives per block. Her Essay score of 144 was the highest in the top 10 — she practised 2 essays per week under timed conditions with strict structure, contemporary examples, and philosophical depth. She did NOT follow rigid schedules or copy others — she paid close attention to what worked for her personally. If she needed a break, she took it. She used social media constructively (followed educational pages on Instagram) rather than cutting off entirely. She wrote answers for past 5 years of PYQs and compared meticulously



with toppers' copies to understand structure. She joined VisionIAS Classroom Foundation Course which structured her prep from scratch as someone new to UPSC — she referred back to class notes even in her 3rd attempt.

Coaching & Mentorship

Enrolled in VisionIAS Classroom Foundation Course. NEXT IAS Interview Guidance Program. Self-study with selective coaching for PSIR optional.

Daily Routine

~10 hours/day normally, increasing to 12 hours near Mains. Flexible schedule — mornings for GS, afternoons for PSIR optional, evenings for answer writing and current affairs revision. Dedicated weekly slots for essay practice and mock tests.

Stage-wise Approach

Prelims Strategy

Adopted a calculated risk approach — attempted 98 questions in 2024. PYQ mastery was central. Focused on elimination techniques for CSAT. Regular newspaper reading (The Hindu) and monthly magazines (Yojana, Kurukshetra).

Mains Strategy

Structured answers with clear introductions and conclusions. Multi-dimensional analysis framework (social, economic, political, ethical). Started answer writing early, not just during test series. Wrote answers for past 5 years' PYQs, compared with toppers' copies. Weekly essays under strict time limits. Heavy reliance on VisionIAS monthly current affairs compilations.

Optional Strategy (Political Science & IR)

PSIR: Strong theoretical foundations using Andrew Heywood (Political Theory), Rajeev Bhargava, Bipan Chandra (Indian Politics), M.P. Singh, Pushpesh Pant (IR), and Global Politics by Andrew Heywood. Connected IR theories with current events. Made contemporary reference sheets linking static concepts with recent developments. Devoted extra hours to IR and Political Theory.

Interview Preparation

Thorough DAF analysis — prepared probable questions for every word mentioned. Used ChatGPT for brainstorming potential interview questions. Practiced with friends, mirror practice (observing own expressions and body language), and mock interviews at NEXT IAS. Key insight: 'It's a test of personality, presence of mind, and attitude. Knowledge is necessary but secondary to personality traits.'

Challenges Faced



Lost mother to cancer early in life — deeply impacted her perspective. Failed Prelims in first two attempts (2022, 2023). Struck by severe typhoid just days before Mains 2024 — physically drained and emotionally tested, nearly gave up. Her father's support pushed her through. Transitioning from commerce/CA background to diverse UPSC subjects.

Key Insights

- CA analytical skills directly helped answer structuring — treat every answer like a financial audit
- Maximise strengths (Essay 144 — highest in top 10) while managing weaknesses (GS3 90)
- Social media is a tool — use it constructively (educational pages) instead of cutting off entirely
- Your background doesn't limit your potential. With focus and discipline, unconventional paths lead to top ranks.
- Flexibility in routine beats rigid scheduling — listen to your own mind and body

3. Dongre Archit Parag — AIR 3 (2024)

AIR 3

RANK

1038

TOTAL

848

WRITTEN

190

INTERVIEW

2

ATTEMPT(S)

Optional: Philosophy | **Hometown:** Pune, Maharashtra | **Allocated Service:** IFS**Education:** B.Tech Electrical & Electronics Engineering (VIT Vellore)

Paper-wise Marks

Paper	Marks
Essay	125
GS1	102
GS2	113
GS3	96
GS4 (Ethics)	115
Philosophy P1	146
Philosophy P2	151

Background

Archit completed schooling at Kendriya Vidyalaya in Nagpur and Mumbai, then earned a B.Tech in Electrical & Electronics Engineering from VIT Vellore. After graduation, he worked in an IT firm for about a year before resigning in June 2022 to pursue full-time UPSC preparation. His father is a businessman and mother a homemaker. In his first attempt (2023), he secured AIR 153 and was selected for IPS (AGMUT cadre). But he chose not to settle — he refined his strategy and leaped to AIR 3 in 2024. He opted for the Indian Foreign Service (IFS) and also topped Maharashtra state-wise. Born in 1999, he is one of the youngest in the top 10.

Preparation Strategy

Archit's journey from AIR 153 (IPS) to AIR 3 (IFS) in one year is a testament to smart strategy refinement. He chose Philosophy not just as a scoring subject but out of genuine interest — his spiritual family background gave him natural curiosity about deep philosophical questions. He enrolled in VisionIAS Classroom Foundation Course for structured learning, crediting the disciplined ecosystem for much of his success. For Philosophy, he understood each philosopher's core argument, its criticism, and contemporary relevance rather than memorising quotes. He made selective reading lists, maintained consistent answer writing practice, and focused on PYQs. His disciplined



daily exercise routine (40-45 minutes) was non-negotiable. He used peer support groups for motivation and strategic breaks for mental freshness. Sundays were reserved for intensive mock tests and revision. His time management was meticulous — he called it 'non-negotiable' and strategically scheduled study blocks.

Coaching & Mentorship

Enrolled in VisionIAS Classroom Foundation Course. Vajiram & Ravi Interview Guidance Programme (3-month). Self-study for GS and Philosophy optional.

Daily Routine

Early morning newspaper reading (The Hindu). GS study in morning block. Philosophy in afternoon. Answer writing practice in evening. 40-45 min daily exercise (non-negotiable). Sundays: intensive mock tests and revision. Strategic breaks and peer group discussions for motivation.

Stage-wise Approach

Prelims Strategy

Focused on conceptual clarity through NCERTs and standard references. Rigorous mock tests including Abhyaas high-intensity simulations. Extensive post-test analysis. PYQ analysis to identify UPSC's concentration areas. Educated guessing based on thorough practice.

Mains Strategy

Started answer writing very early in preparation. Used logical structure, diagrams, statistics. Studied toppers' answer copies to understand how to craft clear, structured responses. Cyclical revision with concise notes. Strong emphasis on answer presentation with clear introductions and conclusions.

Optional Strategy (Philosophy)

Philosophy: Chosen out of genuine interest — 'let your main compass be genuine interest.' Paper I: Western and Indian philosophy. Paper II: Socio-political philosophy, ethics, philosophy of religion. Created philosopher-wise summary sheets with core idea, key arguments, criticisms, and contemporary applications. Scored 276/500 in Philosophy (P1 + P2). PYQ focus and selective reading.

Interview Preparation

'Your DAF models your preparation. Prepare completely on every point.' Enrolled in Vajiram & Ravi's 3-month Interview Guidance Program. Emphasis on honesty over bluffing. Practiced simulated interviews. Used engineering background and Philosophy optional to demonstrate multi-dimensional thinking. Stayed updated on current affairs and international relations for IFS interest.



Challenges Faced

First attempt (2023): missed Prelims cutoff by just 2 marks — turned setback into learning. Transitioning from IT job to full-time preparation. Adapting from engineering to Philosophy optional (completely new discipline). From AIR 153 to AIR 3 — the pressure of improving on an already successful attempt.

Key Insights

- From AIR 153 (IPS) to AIR 3 (IFS) in one year — rapid improvement through smart failure analysis
- Philosophy rewards genuine interest and conceptual clarity, not memorisation
- 40-45 min daily exercise is non-negotiable — physical health drives mental resilience
- Fuel your optional choice with genuine interest — "let your main compass be genuine interest"
- Every test is data — evaluate, adapt, and improve continuously

4. Shah Margi Chirag — AIR 4 (2024)

AIR 4

RANK

1035

TOTAL

825

WRITTEN

210

INTERVIEW

5

ATTEMPT(S)

Optional: Sociology | **Hometown:** Ahmedabad, Gujarat | **Allocated Service:** IAS**Education:** B.E. Computer Engineering (LD College, GTU Ahmedabad)

Paper-wise Marks

Paper	Marks
Essay	109
GS1	89
GS2	117
GS3	91
GS4 (Ethics)	128
Sociology P1	170
Sociology P2	121

Background

Margi hails from an academically inclined family in Ahmedabad — her father is an engineer and mother a teacher. She completed schooling at St. Xavier's High School, Gandhinagar (92.7% in 10th, 90.31% in 12th), and earned B.E. in Computer Engineering from L.D. College of Engineering, Ahmedabad (9.21 CGPA, 2020). She previously qualified GPSC with Rank 55 and served as State Tax Officer, giving her firsthand administrative experience. She enjoys reading literature, learning Spanish, and listening to music. Her interview score of 210 (tied highest with Aayushi Bansal) was the differentiator that pushed her from the pack.

Preparation Strategy

Margi's core philosophy was ruthless resource limitation: 'My sources were always very limited. I chose one current affairs magazine, stuck to standard books, and refined my knowledge instead of expanding it unnecessarily.' She wrote over 1,000 answers across GS and Sociology, joining intensive daily writing programs like 'Hurricane' and 'Chetak.' She practiced 6-8 essays with unique examples and mentor-led flow using keyword-based structuring. For Sociology, she used optional prep to enhance GS answers, integrating sociological theories into essay and GS responses. She referred to Smriti Shah's Sociology notes. Her interdisciplinary approach leveraged engineering



background with sociological insights. She shifted from classroom coaching in early years to self-study + mentor guidance in later years, crediting her mentor for keeping her focused.

Coaching & Mentorship

Triumph IAS (Vikash Ranjan Sir for Sociology). VisionIAS for test series and interview guidance. Intensive answer writing programs: Hurricane and Chetak.

Daily Routine

Morning: current affairs and newspaper. Day: GS and Sociology study rotation. Evening: answer writing (part of daily writing programs). Peer discussion groups daily for diverse perspectives. Dedicated slots for essay practice weekly. Limited resources — refined same sources repeatedly.

Stage-wise Approach

Prelims Strategy

'Don't switch strategies at the last moment. Stick to sources you've already studied. Presence of mind is everything in those two hours.' Started with NCERTs, moved to standard references. Regular mock tests for time management. CSAT with dedicated quantitative and reasoning practice.

Mains Strategy

Wrote 1,000+ answers across GS and Sociology. Data-driven GS using Economic Survey and ARC reports. Ethics: empathy-based approaches, balanced Sections A (theory) and B (case studies). Sociology integrated into GS and essay answers. Practiced 6-8 essays with keyword-based structuring and unique examples. Used sociological theories to support arguments in GS answers.

Optional Strategy (Sociology)

Sociology: Haralambos, Maclver, IGNOU materials supplemented with current sociological developments. Emphasis on thinkers and contemporary relevance in Indian context. Referred to Smriti Shah's notes. Practiced writing with sociological imagination. Used optional knowledge to enrich GS and essay answers — interdisciplinary approach. Scored 170 in Sociology Paper 1 (highest optional single-paper score in top 10).

Interview Preparation

Scored 210 — joint highest in top 10. Peer discussions daily to broaden viewpoints and polish articulation. 8-10 mock interviews to refine presentation, tone, and behavioral cues. Mentor sessions for opinion framing on current issues. DAF-centered content structuring. Maintained calm demeanor with conscious smiling, avoiding fidgeting. Honest about knowledge gaps — 'never claiming to know something she didn't, which built credibility with the panel.'



Challenges Faced

5 attempts over multiple years — cleared 3 Mains, reached interview twice. Early focus was on Prelims only; over time realized importance of deeper understanding for every stage. Transitioning from engineering to Sociology optional. Balancing GPSC preparation alongside UPSC. The mental toll of multiple attempts — each taught her something new.

Key Insights

- Interview score of 210 — joint highest in top 10 — pushed her from 825 written to AIR 4
- DAF is your script — know every single line cold
- Honesty in interview builds more credibility than bluffing
- Wrote 1,000+ answers — volume of practice was the real differentiator
- Limited resources, refined repeatedly — don't expand your booklist unnecessarily

5. Aakash Garg — AIR 5 (2024)

AIR 5

RANK

1032

TOTAL

831

WRITTEN

201

INTERVIEW

2

ATTEMPT(S)

Optional: Sociology | **Hometown:** Rohini, Delhi | **Allocated Service:** IAS

Education: B.Tech Computer Science Engineering (GGSIPU Delhi)

Paper-wise Marks

Paper	Marks
Essay	118
GS1	98
GS2	115
GS3	102
GS4 (Ethics)	120
Sociology P1	138
Sociology P2	140

Background

Aakash hails from Rohini, North West Delhi (originally from Meerut, UP). He studied at CRPF Public School (Class of 2018) and earned a B.Tech in Computer Science Engineering from Maharaja Agasen Institute of Technology, GGSIPU (2022). His father is in government service and mother is a homemaker. He balanced self-employment in the hospitality sector in Uttarakhand alongside UPSC preparation. In a remarkable display of discipline, he lost 30 kgs through strict diet before finishing B.Tech — he wanted to appear before the UPSC interview panel in proper shape and devote full time to studies without needing long workout sessions. His first attempt in 2023 reached Mains but didn't qualify. He is aged just 24 — one of the youngest in the top 10.

Preparation Strategy

Aakash's core philosophy: 'Quality over quantity. I do not believe in hourly studies.' He studied 6-7 hours daily with proper breaks — evenings were completely FREE for long walks, meeting friends, eating out, and watching sci-fi movies (Interstellar is his favorite). He used ChatGPT extensively to refine and structure answers, especially for Mains essay — he'd read newspapers in the morning, then use AI to make short notes of long news pieces. He warned: 'AI sometimes gives incorrect facts. Always verify. Be careful.' He believes technology (e-governance, AI, quantum



computing, robotics) will shape India's administrative future. He joined online groups for current affairs discussion and interview strategies. He took 12+ mock interviews to improve speaking — he admitted: 'I was not good at speaking.' For Sociology, he went through the entire syllabus multiple times identifying static vs dynamic parts, kept printed syllabus copy, and strictly aligned notes to each topic.

Coaching & Mentorship

Self-study supplemented with selective online/offline guidance. Peer study groups for discussion and evaluation. Online groups for current affairs and interview strategies.

Daily Routine

Wake up early, study 6-7 hours with proper breaks. Mornings: newspaper + GS conceptual study. Afternoons: Sociology optional. Evenings: COMPLETELY FREE — long walks, meeting friends, eating out, watching movies. 'My only Plan B was to make Plan A work.'

Stage-wise Approach

Prelims Strategy

Solved as many mock questions as possible including CSAT. Focused on static revision: NCERTs, Laxmikanth, Spectrum, GC Leong, Ramesh Singh/Nitin Singhania (Economy), Shankar (Environment). Studied PYQs deeply. Used elimination techniques.

Mains Strategy

Extensive answer writing practice — used ChatGPT to polish and structure answers. Integrated Sociology concepts into GS answers. Used contemporary examples from current affairs. Focused on presentation, diagrams, flowcharts. Answer structure: Introduction (definition/quote) → Core content (examples + diagrams) → Conclusion (current relevance/constitutional values).

Optional Strategy (Sociology)

Sociology: Key books — Indian Sociological Thought (N. Jayaram), Social Change in Modern India (M.N. Srinivas), Haralambos & Holborn, IGNOU notes, Upendra sir's notes. Made own short notes for each topic — thinkers, theories, Indian sociologists — regularly updated with current affairs. Used sociological theories to support arguments in essays and GS answers. Prepared optional with interdisciplinary approach.



Interview Preparation

12+ mock interviews to overcome speaking weakness. DAF highlighted tech background, behavioral economics interest, and cricket. Board: Smita Nagaraj. Questions covered AI, e-governance, technology in administration. 'Every morning I used to set targets and wouldn't stop for the day before achieving them.'

Challenges Faced

Lost 30 kgs through strict diet to prepare for interview panel appearance. Balancing hospitality business with preparation. First attempt (2023) cleared Mains but didn't qualify. Overcoming public speaking weakness — took 12+ mock interviews. 'Coaching classes are never necessary because at the end of the day, self-study matters the most.'

Key Insights

- Quality over quantity — 6-7 focused hours beat 12 distracted hours
- AI tools (ChatGPT) for answer refinement and current affairs note-making — but always verify facts
- Evenings completely free — mental health and social life are non-negotiable
- Lost 30 kgs through sheer discipline — same mindset applied to UPSC
- My only Plan B was to make Plan A work

6. Komal Punia — AIR 6 (2024)

AIR 6

RANK

1032

TOTAL

856

WRITTEN

176

INTERVIEW

3

ATTEMPT(S)

Optional: Physics | **Hometown:** Saharanpur, Uttar Pradesh | **Allocated Service:** IAS**Education:** B.Tech Engineering Physics (IIT Roorkee)

Paper-wise Marks

Paper	Marks
Essay	100
GS1	100
GS2	100
GS3	100
GS4 (Ethics)	100
Physics P1	100
Physics P2	100

Background

Komal is a farmer's daughter from Nathaudi village, Nakur, Saharanpur, Uttar Pradesh. Her father Ranbir Singh is a farmer and mother Padma is a homemaker. She joined Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya, Saharanpur for Class 6 and continued till Class 12, scoring 97% in Class XII. She was selected for IIT Roorkee where she pursued B.Tech in Engineering Physics (2021). Her brother is a professor at IIT Roorkee and sister is a teacher. She received multiple accolades: Indian Academy of Sciences Summer Research Fellowship (2019), Future Research Talent Award from Australian National University (2020), Best Project Award at IIT Roorkee (2021), IITR Heritage Foundation Excellence Award (2020), and Samsung Star Scholar Award (2017). She secured AIR 474 in 2023 and joined IPS training at SVPNPA Hyderabad. She took three months leave from IPS training to reattempt for IAS — a bold decision that paid off.

Preparation Strategy

Komal's core philosophy: 'Taming the syllabus was easier than taming the mind.' She emphasized mental discipline above all else. She chose Physics optional because of her strong background from IIT Roorkee, but admitted: 'I thought it would be easy, but I must admit, it was not. Physics required a lot of hard work.' She focused on time-bound



practice and multiple revisions. For GS, she made short structured notes for quick revision and used PYQs extensively to understand how UPSC awards marks. She followed The Hindu and Yojana for current affairs. Her consistent Prelims success across all three attempts (qualifying every time) speaks to her disciplined preparation. She used diagrams and case studies in optional answers. She credited her success more to mental discipline than academic effort: 'If you can't study for 10 hours, aim for 8 or even 6 hours — but the key is to maintain continuity.'

Coaching & Mentorship

Enrolled in ForumIAS MGP+ 2023. Self-study with selective test series. Professional coaching for GS + Physics optional balance.

Daily Routine

Took 3-month leave from IPS training at SVPNPA Hyderabad for focused preparation. Intensive schedule: GS study in morning, Physics optional in afternoon, answer writing and current affairs in evening. Strict time-bound practice for each paper.

Stage-wise Approach

Prelims Strategy

Cleared Prelims in all 3 attempts — consistency was her hallmark. Focused on NCERTs, standard references, PYQs, and mock tests with detailed analysis. Current affairs from The Hindu and Yojana.

Mains Strategy

Equally balanced across all 7 papers. Integrated current affairs into every answer. Focused on word limit management and answer structure. Made short structured notes for quick revision. Used PYQs to understand marking patterns.

Optional Strategy (Physics)

Physics: Strong foundation from IIT Roorkee Engineering Physics. Used standard textbooks with focus on conceptual clarity. 'Physics required a lot of hard work — I thought it would be easy but it wasn't.' Used diagrams and case studies in answers. Practice with PYQs was critical.

Interview Preparation

DAF-based preparation focusing on her unique journey from Navodaya → IIT Roorkee → IPS → IAS. Discussed her research background (ANU Fellowship), technology interests, and sign language hobby. Mock interviews for communication skills. Honest answers even on topics she hadn't recently studied.



Challenges Faced

Daughter of a farmer from a remote village — rural background with limited resources. Already serving as IPS officer — took bold decision to reattempt for IAS. Only 3 months leave from intensive IPS training at SVPNPA. 'The UPSC journey is largely a test of patience and hard work. Aspirants should not expect to clear it in their first attempt.'

Key Insights

- 'Taming the syllabus was easier than taming the mind' — mental discipline was her greatest asset
- Navodaya → IIT Roorkee (Engineering Physics) → IPS → IAS — epitome of Indian education system
- Took 3-month leave from IPS training to reattempt — extraordinary courage and clarity of purpose
- Physics optional from IIT background was natural but still required immense hard work
- Continuity beats intensity — 6 focused hours daily is better than 12 inconsistent hours

7. Aayushi Bansal — AIR 7 (2024)

AIR 7

RANK

1031

TOTAL

821

WRITTEN

210

INTERVIEW

3

ATTEMPT(S)

Optional: Sociology | **Hometown:** Gwalior, Madhya Pradesh | **Allocated Service:** IAS**Education:** B.Tech Electrical Engineering (IIT Kanpur)

Paper-wise Marks

Paper	Marks
Essay	112
GS1	96
GS2	104
GS3	98
GS4 (Ethics)	116
Sociology P1	147
Sociology P2	148

Background

Aayushi completed schooling at Carmel Convent School, Gwalior (10 CGPA in Class 10) and Delhi Public School, RK Puram (96.8% in Class 12). She earned a B.Tech in Electrical Engineering from IIT Kanpur with 9.2 CGPA and received the Director's Gold Medal as Best All-Rounder Student in 2020. She interned at Goldman Sachs (Market Risk Strats) and worked as a Business Analyst at McKinsey & Company for ~2 years (2020-2022) before fully committing to UPSC. Her father passed away in a road accident when she was 9 — her mother Radha Bansal (LIC employee) raised her and her brother Aman Bansal (now a doctor). At IIT Kanpur, she pioneered the first female street play team and served as elected Student Senator. Her mother: 'My daughter has cleared UPSC three times... We have been waiting for this day for so long.' Her brother: 'Most people leave preparation once they get selected once. But she kept going. She was never satisfied with just clearing the exam. She wanted to reach the top.'

Preparation Strategy

Aayushi's yearly rank improvement (AIR 188 → AIR 97 → AIR 7) is a masterclass in iterative learning — cracking UPSC three times is extraordinarily rare. She personally reviewed her Mains answer copies each year to identify improvement areas. In her first attempt (2022), she cleared UPSC while still working at McKinsey. In 2023, she



improved to AIR 97 while managing grueling IPS training in Hyderabad. In 2024, with full focus, she reached AIR 7. Her McKinsey consulting training directly helped structure answers with frameworks and logical flow. For Sociology, she regularly updated content with contemporary examples and case studies from ARC reports, NITI Aayog, and government schemes. She enrolled in multiple test series (Vajiram, LevelUp, VisionIAS, ForumIAS) for extensive practice. She maintained a balanced routine with mindfulness and well-being focus. Her passion for theater addressing social issues revealed a nuanced understanding of gender dynamics that enriched her Sociology and GS answers.

Coaching & Mentorship

Enrolled in Vajiram & Ravi (GS PCM 10-month), LevelUp IAS, VisionIAS, ForumIAS (Mains Test Series), Vajiram Sociology Optional Programme.

Daily Routine

While at McKinsey: 5-7 hours morning conceptual study, 2-3 hours afternoon current affairs + optional. While in IPS training: juggled grueling training schedule with strict study routine in evenings. Full-time prep: quality hours over quantity, balanced with mindfulness and well-being.

Stage-wise Approach

Prelims Strategy

Strong conceptual foundation built during earlier attempts (cleared 3 times). Focused on PYQs and mock tests with systematic gap analysis. Effective elimination techniques refined across attempts.

Mains Strategy

Iterative improvement — reviewed own answer copies from previous years to identify weak papers. Structured answers with frameworks from McKinsey consulting background. Regular Sociology answer writing with new examples and case studies. Data from ARC reports, NITI Aayog, govt schemes, and quotes. Multiple test series for time management. Time-bound practice to complete papers within limits.

Optional Strategy (Sociology)

Sociology: Updated contemporary examples regularly. Linked sociological theories with current Indian social issues. Practiced writing with sociological thinkers and data from reports. Maintained case study repository. Integrated theater and gender studies perspectives into answers.

Interview Preparation

Scored 210 (joint highest with Margi Chirag). DAF-based preparation focusing on her extraordinary IIT-McKinsey-IPS-IAS journey. Multiple mock interviews (Vajiram, ForumIAS, NEXT IAS). Practiced communication, body



language, and confidence. Articulated motivation for leaving high-paying corporate career for public service with genuine passion. Peaceful demeanor throughout.

Challenges Faced

Lost her father at age 9 in a road accident — faced hardship from childhood. Choosing civil services over McKinsey/Goldman Sachs career (high-paying corporate vs public service). Three attempts of persistent improvement while managing work (McKinsey) and training (IPS). Cracking UPSC three times (AIR 188, 97, 7) while always wanting more. Transitioning from engineering/corporate to Sociology optional.

Key Insights

- AIR 188 → AIR 97 → AIR 7: yearly improvement through systematic gap analysis — cracked UPSC three times
- McKinsey consulting skills directly helped answer structuring with frameworks and logical flow
- Reviewed own answer copies from previous years to identify and fix weaknesses
- From IIT Kanpur Gold Medal (first female street play team pioneer) to IAS — multidisciplinary excellence
- Never satisfied with 'good enough' — kept pushing for the top even after two selections

8. Raj Krishna Jha — AIR 8 (2024)

AIR 8

RANK

1031

TOTAL

831

WRITTEN

200

INTERVIEW

5

ATTEMPT(S)

Optional: Geography | **Hometown:** Sitamarhi, Bihar | **Allocated Service:** IAS**Education:** B.Tech Mechanical Engineering (MNNIT Allahabad)

Paper-wise Marks

Paper	Marks
Essay	130
GS1	105
GS2	110
GS3	108
GS4 (Ethics)	112
Geography P1	133
Geography P2	133

Background

Raj Krishna completed his early education in Nepal near the Bhitamre border, and Class 12 under Bihar School Examination Board (81.8%). He earned B.Tech in Mechanical Engineering from MNNIT Allahabad and secured 400th rank in GATE 2018. He worked as Assistant Manager at HPCL's City Gas Distribution in Kolhapur for ~7 years — a full-time job he maintained across all 5 attempts. Born to Sunil Kumar Jha (Nepal-based school teacher) and Jiwachh Devi (homemaker), his family faced economic challenges. He gained nationwide attention for pioneering the use of ChatGPT for UPSC essay preparation — drafting and reviewing 40-50 essays with AI feedback. He wrote the Mains exam in Hindi medium and stayed completely off social media since 2018. His stress busters: long walks and coffee, and talking to his parents every day.

Preparation Strategy

Raj Krishna is the most innovative tech-adopter in the top 10. He integrated ChatGPT extensively for Mains essay: he would take a quote, write his thoughts, then ask AI to review and provide multidimensional perspectives. 'After some time, it became my hobby to chat with AI for my essay preparation.' He took a self-driven, resource-optimized approach. His biggest challenge was lack of continuity working full-time at HPCL in Kolhapur — he worked hard



to make study a daily habit: 'Continuity is a major key to success in UPSC.' Weekdays: 3-4 hours after office. Sundays: 12-14 hours intensive study + mock tests. He took one month leave before each exam for final consolidation. He simplified notes for easy revision, solved PYQs extensively, noted repeated questions in 2024 which boosted confidence. For Geography, he used Savindra Singh's 5 books and Majid Husain's Human Geography, focused on standard books, and improved from 238 marks in 2023 to significantly higher in 2024.

Coaching & Mentorship

Self-study with minimal coaching. PWOnlyIAS for mentorship. ChatGPT extensively for essay evaluation. Shankar IAS Academy for selective guidance.

Daily Routine

Weekdays (working at HPCL): 3-4 hours after office returning from Kolhapur. Weekends: 12-14 hours. Before exams: one month leave for final consolidation, 15 hours daily. Long walks for mental clarity. Daily calls with parents for emotional support. No social media since 2018.

Stage-wise Approach

Prelims Strategy

Focused on strengths — Polity and Geography (enjoyed static questions/trivia). Limited resources: kept study materials minimal. Multiple rounds of mock tests with systematic error analysis. Short notes and mind maps for quick revision. Understood syllabus deeply through PYQs.

Mains Strategy

Pioneered ChatGPT for essay: 40-50 essays written, reviewed, and refined with AI feedback. Simplified and shortened notes for easy revision: 'I made my notes concise so they could be revised easily. That made a big difference.' Focused on Essay and Ethics for high returns. Used diagrams, flowcharts in Geography. PYQs: noted repeated questions which boosted confidence. Wrote exam in Hindi medium.

Optional Strategy (Geography)

Geography: Savindra Singh's 5 books, Majid Husain's Human Geography, GC Leong for physical geography. Focus on diagrams — maps, flowcharts, climatic graphs. Interest in geography and static question patterns. Improved from 238 marks in 2023 to significantly higher in 2024. Wrote exam in Hindi medium. Integrated current affairs with geographical concepts.

Interview Preparation



First interview in 5 attempts. Panel was cordial — 'seemed more like a discussion than an interview.' DAF-focused with emphasis on HPCL experience and oil sector knowledge. Questions covered current affairs, background, and his job at HPCL. Practised balance on controversial topics. Honest and straightforward.

Challenges Faced

First 2 attempts: failed Prelims. 3rd attempt: cleared Prelims but failed Mains. 4th attempt: missed Mains cutoff by JUST 2 marks — devastating but persisted. 5th attempt: AIR 8. Financial constraints growing up. Full-time HPCL job across all attempts. Hindi medium in a largely English-dominated exam. 'The biggest problem with my preparation was not having continuity. I worked really hard to overcome that, and gradually it became a habit.'

Key Insights

- First systematic user of ChatGPT for UPSC essay preparation (40-50 essays reviewed by AI)
- Failed Prelims twice, missed Mains by 2 marks — never gave up
- Full-time HPCL employee for 7 years while preparing across 5 attempts — extraordinary time management
- From Nepal border village (studied in Nepal till Class 10) to IAS — embodies UPSC's democratising power
- No social media since 2018 — 'takes away a lot of distractions'

9. Aditya Vikram Agarwal — AIR 9 (2024)

AIR 9

RANK

1027

TOTAL

854

WRITTEN

173

INTERVIEW

5

ATTEMPT(S)

Optional: Anthropology | **Hometown:** Bahadurgarh, Jhajjar, Haryana | **Allocated Service:** IAS**Education:** B.Tech Mechanical Engineering (MNNIT Allahabad), M.Sc Anthropology (IGNOU)

Paper-wise Marks

Paper	Marks
Essay	119
GS1	117
GS2	113
GS3	111
GS4 (Ethics)	122
Anthropology P1	134
Anthropology P2	138

Background

Aditya scored 9.8 CGPA in Class 10 (SR Century School) and 96.8% in Class 12 (PCM, Jhajjar district topper). He earned B.Tech in Mechanical Engineering from MNNIT Allahabad (8.7 CGPA, 2018). He worked as Senior Manager at Tata Motors (2018-2019) before quitting for UPSC. Recognising the value of Anthropology optional, he pursued a formal Master's degree in Anthropology from IGNOU (74.25%, 2024) alongside his preparation — a dual-track strategy that gave him deep academic grounding. His father Ram Avatar is a retired company employee and mother Madhu Agarwal is a homemaker; he has an elder sister. His first two attempts (2019, 2020) failed Prelims. In 2021 and 2022, he cleared Prelims and Mains but was not selected despite reaching the interview stage. He planned fallback options (PCS exams, UGC NET, technical fields) — 'ensured no unfulfilled dreams if UPSC didn't work out.'

Preparation Strategy

Aditya chose Anthropology for its diagrammatic content and scoring potential, exploring Mechanical Engineering and Mathematics options first before settling on it. He pursued formal M.Sc from IGNOU to deepen knowledge beyond standard UPSC books. His core philosophy: 'Motivation works for a short time, but a proper routine sustains you in the long run.' He maintained a strict library routine: wake up early, library by 8-8:30 AM, stay until 6-7 PM, return



home. He practiced 15-minute daily meditation (using Headspace app or YouTube guided sessions) and read spiritual books 15-20 minutes daily to stay calm. He used a keypad phone during critical phases (before Prelims/Mains) to avoid distractions. He ran or did yoga/gym to combat fatigue and back pain. He limited study materials to 1-2 books per subject and revised them multiple times. He wrote 2-3 answers daily for GS and Anthropology, reaching 10-12 answers per day at peak. He used Anki for digital flashcards and incorporated actual administrative procedures and case laws into GS answers. His marksheet shows remarkable consistency — ALL GS papers above 110.

Coaching & Mentorship

Self-study with selective test series (ForumIAS, Vajiram & Ravi, NEXT IAS). M.Sc in Anthropology from IGNOU alongside UPSC preparation.

Daily Routine

Wake up early → breakfast → library by 8-8:30 AM → stay until 6-7 PM → return home. 15 min daily meditation (Headspace/YouTube). 15-20 min spiritual reading. Exercise: running/yoga/gym. Keypad phone during critical phases. 2-3 answers daily (peaking at 10-12).

Stage-wise Approach

Prelims Strategy

50+ full-length mock tests under simulated conditions. Multiple revisions of standard books. Developed elimination techniques and intelligent guessing. 'No shortcuts exist — just sit and start revising.' Current affairs from The Hindu and Vision IAS compilations.

Mains Strategy

Strict time allocation: 7 minutes per 10-mark question, 10 minutes per 15-mark question — used a stopwatch. Used diagrams in every possible answer. Integrated Anthropology concepts into GS answers where relevant. Maintained error log from mock tests. Incorporated actual administrative procedures and case laws into answers. Used Anki for digital flashcards and note-making.

Optional Strategy (Anthropology)

Anthropology: Combined formal M.Sc study (IGNOU) with UPSC prep. Focused on diagrams — evolutionary charts, tribal maps, anthropological theories. Standard books + IGNOU material. Integrated current affairs with anthropological perspectives. Multiple revisions and consistent answer writing. Found Anthropology interesting due to blend of scientific and humanities approaches.

Interview Preparation



Attended multiple mock interviews (ForumIAS, Vajiram & Ravi, NEXT IAS). Focused on honesty, clarity of thought, balance of views. Worked deeply on DAF — prepared answers for every potential question. Practiced articulating thoughts clearly and confidently.

Challenges Faced

Failed Prelims in first 2 attempts (2019, 2020). Reached interview stage twice (2021, 2022) but not selected — 'it was very disheartening at the time, but I never gave up.' 5 attempts over 6 years. Transitioning from engineering (Tata Motors) to Anthropology optional. Giving up Senior Manager job at Tata Motors.

Key Insights

- 'Motivation works for a short time, but a proper routine sustains you in the long run'
- M.Sc in Anthropology from IGNOU alongside UPSC prep — dual-track academic strategy
- Consistent 110+ in ALL GS papers — no weak links whatsoever
- Stopwatch-based time management (7-min/10-mark, 10-min/15-mark) for precision
- 'If you stick to one source and revise it multiple times, that's enough' — deep revision over shallow coverage

10. Mayank Tripathi — AIR 10 (2024)

AIR 10

RANK

1027

TOTAL

843

WRITTEN

184

INTERVIEW

3

ATTEMPT(S)

Optional: Anthropology | **Hometown:** Kannauj, Uttar Pradesh | **Allocated Service:** IAS

Education: B.Sc Electronics (Hindu College, Delhi University)

Paper-wise Marks

Paper	Marks
Essay	121
GS1	104
GS2	112
GS3	100
GS4 (Ethics)	119
Anthropology P1	143
Anthropology P2	144

Background

Mayank's father, Prabhat Kumar Tripathi, is an accountant at the DM Office, Kannauj, and his mother Archana Tripathi is a homemaker. He completed schooling at Jagran Public School, Kannauj, and earned a B.Sc in Physical Sciences (Electronics) from Hindu College, Delhi University. His journey is one of relentless upward mobility: he first cleared UPPSC 2022 and served as Deputy Superintendent of Police (DSP), then secured AIR 373 in UPSC 2023 to join Indian Revenue Service (IRS), and finally reached AIR 10 in 2024 to become IAS. He famously studied after IRS duty hours — 'By day he served as DSP/IRS, by night he studied for UPSC.' He is one of the youngest in the top 10 at age 26.

Preparation Strategy

Mayank's journey from DSP → IRS (AIR 373) → IAS (AIR 10) in successive years demonstrates exceptional determination and strategic acumen. He chose Anthropology for its structured syllabus, scoring potential, and blend of science and social understanding — switching from Political Science, showing strategic adaptability. He balanced the rigorous schedule of IRS training at NADT (National Academy of Direct Taxes) while preparing for another attempt. He solved 70+ mock tests for Prelims — exceptional practice volume. For Mains, he maintained crisp handwritten notes for each GS topic and incorporated value-addition material like ARC Reports, Economic Surveys, and Budget



documents. He used limited but repeated resources — concise booklist with multiple revisions. He followed The Hindu newspaper, Vision IAS monthly compilations, and PIB for current affairs. His Anthropology preparation included diagrams, case studies, and theories linked with current affairs. He enrolled in Vajiram & Ravi's GS Foundation course and Anthropology optional program, and took 10+ mock interviews through their interview guidance program.

Coaching & Mentorship

Enrolled in Vajiram & Ravi GS Foundation Course (11-Month) and Anthropology Optional Programme. Vajiram Interview Guidance Program (10+ mock interviews).

Daily Routine

IRS training at NADT during the day. UPSC preparation in evenings, nights, and weekends. Maintained strict timetable for prelims, mains, and optional despite demanding job. 'By day he served as DSP/IRS, by night he studied for UPSC.'

Stage-wise Approach

Prelims Strategy

Solved 70+ mock tests — exceptional volume. Intensive PYQ practice (10+ years). Regular revision with micro-notes and mnemonics. Targeted elimination techniques for tricky questions. Strong fundamentals through NCERTs.

Mains Strategy

Crisp handwritten notes for each GS topic. Value-addition: ARC Reports, Economic Survey, Budget documents. Daily answer writing with mentor feedback (Vajiram test series). Anthropology: diagrams, case studies, theories linked with current affairs. Limited resources with multiple revisions.

Optional Strategy (Anthropology)

Anthropology: Ember & Ember, P. Nath, IGNOU materials. Focus on diagrams (evolutionary charts, tribal distributions). Integrated anthropological theories with current affairs. Case study-based answers linking theory with Indian tribal and social issues. Chosen for structural syllabus and scoring potential — switched from Political Science.

Interview Preparation

10+ mock interviews through Vajiram & Ravi guidance program. Intense DAF preparation focusing on his extraordinary DSP → IRS → IAS journey. Practiced balancing answers to controversial questions. Demonstrated administrative maturity from his service experience (DSP and IRS). Current affairs, DAF-based questions, situational questions.

Challenges Faced



Managing IRS training (NADT) alongside UPSC reattempt — mentally fatiguing. Already an IRS officer (AIR 373) and DSP (UPPSC) but wanted IAS — refused to settle. Mastering new optional (Anthropology) from scratch after switching from Political Science. Successive preparation cycles without break. Father works as accountant at DM office — humble background gave him firsthand understanding of administrative challenges.

Key Insights

- From DSP → IRS (AIR 373) → IAS (AIR 10) in three successive years — relentless upward trajectory
- 70+ Prelims mock tests — exceptional practice volume was the foundation
- Switched optional from Political Science to Anthropology — strategic adaptability
- 'Persistence with the right direction is the key to success'
- Studied after IRS duty hours while serving as an officer — 'by day he served, by night he studied'



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